

Framework

What qualifies as *poetic language* can be any language organised in regular patterns that are transmitted via performance within a social community across generations in various modalities. However, the properties of cross generational transmission and cross-modality apply to just about any social practice and are thus of limited use to actually define or describe *poetic language* as a phenomenon rooted in linguistic systems. However, the statement also contains the fundamental assumption that poetic language is differentiated formally and functionally from the mundane language within which it is embedded. A more linguistically oriented way to frame poetry would be:

A poetic system defines a collection of linguistic patterns which differentiate well-formed poetry from mundane speech. Vice-versa, a poem is a structurally well-formed exemplar of its poetic system such that it can—in isolation—be recognized as a complete poem belonging to said tradition.

If poetic language can be defined by the *recognizability* of its products, then a descriptive approach to it should follow an approach that decomposes these wholes. We will treat *poetic language* as a system of *rules* which incrementally *arranges* linguistic building blocks into larger structures eventually resulting in well formed poetic *compositions*. These building blocks will be treated as hierarchical in the sense that every *arrangement* of building blocks can in turn be used as a single building block in another, higher level of *arrangement*. Poems are thus built incrementally from small *units* which grow larger as it is being composed until the poem is finished and recognizable as such by virtue of its form. It is the representation of these patterns—in a manner that renders them comparable across languages, space and time—which we consider to be novel and unique to our framework.

Units of comparison

The data we collect in the **Poeticlanguage** database should be usable for comparative cross-linguistic and diachronic comparisons across all conceivable poetic practice. Our bookkeeping entities, associated with unique IDs (*PL-entities*), thus represent specific manifestations of poetic practice, as they are composed within a specific *languoid*, dubbed *poetolects* in our framework. This means that every *poetolect* is encoded in its own terms. E.g. a French sonnet is not the same *PL-entity* as an English sonnet. In order to assess the evolution and interaction of *poetic systems*, we try to additionally include information about the influence that they may have had upon each other. E.g. the Finnish Kalevala epos as standardized by E. Lönnrot is not the same *PL-entity* as the earlier, oral manifestation of the *runo-song poetolect* which served as its *predecessor*.

Decomposition

From a decompositional point of view, any poetic *level* LX within a *composition* can be represented in three ways. E.g. consider the following schematic *composition*:

$$\begin{array}{cccccc} \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & || & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \omega\rho_a \\ \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & || & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \omega\rho_b \\ \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & || & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \omega\rho_a \\ \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & || & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \sigma & \omega\rho_b \end{array}$$

1. Within its own terms without exploring internal structure: *The line (LX) has six syllables, followed by a caesura and another five syllables".*

2. As a combination of lower level units (*LX-1*) which serve as building blocks (*constituents*, see below) for the currently described level *LX*: *A line LX consists of the following LX-1 units: two feet, separated by a caesura.*
3. As a *constituent LX* whose purpose it is to be used as a building block of a higher level *LX+1*: *A stanza LX is formed by arranging four lines LX-1 according to an end rhyme scheme abab.*

While approach 1. allows for in-depth descriptive analyses of single *compositions* or even *poetolects*, it is incompatible with our aim to develop comparative concepts for *poetic language*. The reason for this is that with this approach it is impossible to describe the end rhyme scheme *abab* without describing the *composition* as a single, complex, *unit*.

The remaining perspectives 2. and 3. appear to be quite equivalent; however, the former (2.) has some subtle advantages over the latter:

1. It allows us to follow a strict bottom-up approach. I.e. our description of what constitutes a «line» (two «feet» and a «caesura») does not need to encode how the next *level* («stanza») will arrange these «lines».
2. This definition of a *composition* is open-ended in that we do not need to assume a universally applicable poetic structure. Whether a *poetic system* regards a *composition* as *complete* after stacking two or seven *levels* upon each other does not influence the way we analyse it. From this follows that we are not bound by traditional terms like «stanza» or «line» which are often not comparable between different descriptions.
3. Assuming perspective 2., what cannot be described as a combination of a lower *level LX* represents a possibly language-specific *linguistic property* of the *languoid* in which the *poetolect* is embedded. By keeping the definitions of *linguistic properties* as general as possible we draw on general properties of language as a communicative system. We thereby introduce a boundary between the *poetic system* and the *linguistic properties* of the *languoid* in which the system is embedded.
In option 3. we would need a part that treats the grammar of a *languoid* as a *poetic level* to get poetic properties out of the grammar. This would require us to force the grammar of a *languoid* into the coding scheme. As a consequence, cross-linguistic comparability could only be achieved by drawing on a—controversial, to say the least—concept of a predefined grammar for all *languoids*.

What we have in place so far is a framework which allows us to decompose the *poetic system* of any *PL-entity* in such a manner that we split it into *levels* which can be described in isolation of the entire system. What is still missing is a comparative concept which is able to describe according to which *linguistic properties* the *constituents* of an *LX* are *arranged* into patterns to form *valid units*.

Linguistic properties

We assume that the conventionalized rules within the *poetic system* of each *PL-entity* are connected to only a subset of all categories which exist in the linguistic system of the everyday language. This is to say, *poetic language* emphasizes one or several *properties* of everyday language by subjecting their appearance within a *composition* to *constraints* concerning shape, frequency and order of appearance. Since we intend to define a cross-linguistically applicable framework, we deliberately restrict ourselves to assessing only those descriptive *linguistic properties* which are attested at least once to be of relevance to the *rules* of a *poetic system*. This is, instead of operating on a closed set, we dynamically introduce to our typology new descriptive *linguistic properties* by referencing language-independent descriptive categories as needed and keep them as broad as possible to guarantee their applicability across different languages.

Term	Definition
Prosodic prominence	A descriptive linguistic category that exploits prosodic prominence. Prosodically prominent units are linguistic entities that stand out from their environment by virtue of their prosodic characteristics, e.g. they are produced with more effort and perceived with more ease; Prosodic properties which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: stress, beat, ictus, etc. (Terken2000, laddarvaniti2023).
Grammatical quantity	Any descriptive linguistic category that exploits length distinctions. This property does not distinguish whether the quantity is a phonemic quality (/a/ vs. /a:/), a phonotactic phenomenon (E.g. word-final vowel reduction /a/ → /ə/ _#). Grammatical quantity properties which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: phonotactic length, morae and weight. Non-grammatical manifestations of quantity, such as purely emphatic lengthening during performance, are not relevant here.
Syllables	Any descriptive linguistic category that defines the syllabification of speech. Syllable properties which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: syllable shape (e.g. CCVC), count of syllables or a combination thereof.
Phonetic property	A descriptive linguistic category that exploits the characteristics of sound. It may directly relate to phonemes (rhyme), or to features of phonemes (E.g. [+voiced]) . Phonetic properties which have been attested to contribute to some <i>poetic system</i> include: assonance, rhyme, alliteration, ideophones, or fixed phonetic properties such as the requirement of a rhotic in certain positions.
Tone/Phonation property	Any descriptive linguistic category that refers to the characteristics of suprasegmental properties. Tonal or phonation properties which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: pitch, contour, voice quality (creaky, breathy). Explicitly not included are intonational patterns related to <i>chanting</i> and <i>singing</i> .
Pause/caesura	A descriptive linguistic category that refers to how breaks and pauses are placed in the flow of speech. These breaks are not required to coincide with the ending of a word or phrase. Pause/caesura placements which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: word or phrase final or medial pauses; or caesurae.
Word property	Any descriptive linguistic category that applies to lexematic units as a whole. Word properties which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: the part of speech of a word or size (e.g. mono- vs. polysyllabic word). The line between word and syntax is language specific. As a rule of thumb, listings or combinations of words are seen as word-based rules as long as they do not reference grammatical relations.
Morphological property	Any descriptive linguistic category that refers to morphemes and morphologically defined units. Morphological properties which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: roots (etymological figures) or derivational suffixes.

Term	Definition
Syntactic property	Any descriptive linguistic category that refers to syntactic rules, constructions or grammatical relations. Syntactic properties which have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include: clauses, phrases, a required syntactic relation, word-order restrictions or syntactic hierarchy in general.
Semantic property	Any reference to the semantic content of a <i>poetic unit</i> that must or must not be conveyed by a unit. E.g. the persistence of a semantically specified topic such as «love» across a composition, or the repetition of synonymous expressions that refer to «trees» .
Graphematic property	A property defined in reference to a component of a writing system. Depending on the nature of the system this may refer to a whole «glyph», an entire logogram (e.g. in Mandarin), or, more abstractly, some part thereof (e.g. a «radical» in Mandarin).
Narrative Structure	A property that refers to the narrative structure of a <i>poetic unit</i> , typically encompassing a specific progression of dedicated pieces of a narration or its (in)completeness. Attested manifestations include, e.g., introduction-body-closing, adventure-progress-result.
Intonation Phrase	A property defined in reference to the intonational integrity of a unit. Typical manifestations include the prosodic or musical delimitation of a <i>poetic unit</i> .
Performance	A property defined in reference to any aspect of the speech event. Performance related properties that have been attested to contribute to some poetic system include, e.g., turn taking, performance time.
Pragmatics	A property defined in reference to the speech act that defines the poetic system, e.g. competition, verbal combat, argumentation. By this reference to the speech act, a pragmatic property at the poetic rules level differs from the social context registered at the social level and which captures the communicative and social <i>functions</i> of a poetolect.
Other property	Container for properties not previously defined.

In many cases, a *poetic system* may distinguish between different forms which a property can take (i.e. the property is paradigmatic in nature). The slots in such a paradigm are referenced as *forms of a linguistic property* (c.f. *Type (poetic)*). Note that these poetic paradigms are not necessary equal to the full paradigmatic might of the *languoid* in its mundane form. E.g. a rule which makes reference to *word properties* could differentiate between "function words" and "content words" though neither of these categories are, from the viewpoint of descriptive linguistics, adequate descriptive characteristics to describe the grammar of the *languoid*.

Unit size variation

We aim to capture how language, culture and poetic language interact by assessing and comparing a diverse sample of *PL-entities*. To do so, the variation within and across *PL-entities* needs to be registered in a comparable manner across the vast diversity of *poetolects* which can be found in different cultures and languages. Within our framework, we compare abstract units of description designed to serve as a comparative concept, i.e. poetic *levels*. Our framework is designed such that each *level* is described in its own

right, but in the same manner, irrespective of whether it is the lowest or the highest within a *PL-entity's poetic system*.

Any *level* may produce *units* which are all but uniform in size and complexity. This is especially the case if the higher *level* LX+1 distinguishes between different *types* of *constituents*. A uniform assessment of all possible *units* produced at a given *level* risks to systematically exaggerate the complexity of the *units* it produces as well as the diversity of *arrangement* constraints at play. We address this problem by allowing up to four parallel descriptions of each *level's arrangement rules* based on the concept of *complexity*: maximally complex *units* and minimally complex *units* of any *level* LX. For both maximally and minimally complex *units* we distinguish their largest and smallest form of occurrences. For identifying the various unit sizes at any *level* LX of a *poetolect* we apply the following algorithm:

1. For all valid *units* of LX that correspond to *types* (see *Type (poetic)*) at LX+1, how many different forms of all relevant *linguistic properties* are distinguished?
2. The two *units* with the highest and lowest number of forms are coded as minimal (min) and maximal (max) complex, respectively.
3. For all *valid* minimally and maximally complex *units*, the range in terms of largest and smallest number of occurrences

This produces values for four units at each *level* LX:

- largest minimally complex unit (lminC)
- smallest minimally complex unit (sminC)
- largest maximally complex unit (lmaxC)
- smallest maximally complex unit (smaxC)

These values register the extreme values of the variation in complexity and size of valid *units* at *level* LX of a *poetolect*.

The units thus arranged are, in turn, *inherited*, i.e., vertically transmitted to the next hierarchical level of poetic structure to serve as constituents of that level. The arrangement of constituents is subject to *constraints* as well.

Terms and concepts

This section gives an overview of terms and concepts, and the definitions thereof, as used and understood within this project. If terms are based on, or taken from external sources, the literature is cited in the column *Source*. If no citation is present, the definition is a project-specific one.

General concepts

Term	Definition
Poetic language	A linguistically oriented way to frame poetic language is: A poetic system defines a collection of linguistic patterns which differentiate well-formed poetry from mundane speech. Vice-versa, a poem is a structurally well-formed exemplar of its poetic system such that it can—in isolation—be recognized as a complete poem belonging to a poetolect. If poetic language can be defined by the recognisability of its products, then a descriptive approach to it should follow an approach that decomposes these wholes.

Term	Definition
Poetic system	A collection of <i>poetic rules</i> which lead to the composition of a well-formed poem.
Poetic unit, poetic constituent	A <i>poetic unit</i> is a specific and well-formed output at <i>level</i> LX that is defined by one, or co-defined by several <i>linguistic properties</i> . The term LX unit refers abstractly to any well-formed <i>arrangement</i> of LX-1 constituents by a <i>level</i> LX that can in turn be used as a <i>constituent</i> in the next higher <i>level</i> LX+1.
Poetic rule	<i>Poetic rule</i> refers to any linguistically specified rule that determines poetic validity within a <i>poetic system</i> . A <i>poetic rule</i> encompasses an <i>arrangement</i> technique and a <i>poetic unit</i> as its target.
Hierarchical structure	We treat poetic language as a system of <i>poetic rules</i> which incrementally <i>arranges</i> linguistic building blocks into larger structures, resulting in well-formed (valid) poetic <i>compositions</i> . These building blocks are treated as <i>hierarchical</i> in the sense that every <i>arrangement</i> of building blocks can in turn be used as a single building block in another, higher <i>level</i> of <i>arrangement</i> (Ribeiro 2007). Poems are thus built incrementally from small <i>units</i> which grow larger as it is being composed until the poem is finished and recognizable. Our coding is the representation of these patterns in a manner that renders them comparable across languages, cultures, space, and time.
Arrangement	The <i>arrangement</i> rules of a <i>level</i> describe the patterns according to which the selection of constituents within a <i>unit</i> is constrained. Each <i>arrangement</i> rule describes the syntagmatic relation between the occurrences of forms by imposing a specific <i>constraint</i> , i.e. count, ordering, covariation, etc.

Metadata

Term	Definition
PL-entity	<i>PL-entity</i> is a bookkeeping entity representing a <i>poetolect</i> , associated with unique IDs which constitute the basis for encoding in the Poetic-Language database.
Tradition	A <i>tradition</i> is a clustering abstraction over <i>poetolects</i> and emerges as <i>poetolects</i> are analysed and compared.
Languoid	We require each <i>PL-entity</i> to be associated with a specific language; for our purposes we use glottocodes as a reference. If no glottocode is available we use the glottocode of the closest relative as a preliminary encoding. (cf. the Glottolog definition)

Term	Definition
Poetolect	An socio-linguistically defined poetic practice, anchored within an established set of poetical rules and social conventions concerning performance and reception (<i>poetic system</i>). A <i>Poetolect</i> refers to a <i>poetic system</i> described in a specific document. For example, whatever <i>poetic system</i> is contained in a certain description or specific article—or a chapter therein—represents a unique <i>poetolect</i> . <i>Poetolects</i> are associated with unique IDs (<i>PL-entities</i>) and represent specific instantiations of a poetic practice. Every <i>poetolect</i> is <i>languoid</i> -specific and encoded in its own terms. We always report the <i>poetolect</i> as emically defined, mediated through the description. In accordance with the use of the term <i>doculect</i> , the use of the term <i>poetolect</i> (s. Glottopedia) is meant to remind researchers of the fact that poetry may show high internal variability.
Documentation file	An extensive (guided qualitative) description of a <i>PL-entity</i> whose purpose is to describe the <i>poetolect</i> at hand as densely as possible, while still giving space to information which we are not able to assess within our database structure. Creating documentations is one of the first step towards encoding <i>PL-entities</i> as data in the <i>data file</i> . <i>Documentation files</i> are stored in <code>poeticlanguage/Documentations/</code> , in markdown format (<code>.md</code>).
Data file	For each <i>PL-entity</i> , the values of the variables corresponding to each <i>LX</i> , i.e. the answers to the questions asked in the questionnaire, are stored separately in a <code>.ods</code> formatted data file in <code>poeticlanguage/Data/</code> . (cf. Database Structure)
Inventory	The central metadata storage of the database. Stored as <code>poeticlanguage/Metadata/Inventory.csv</code> . It lists the <i>poetolect</i> and <i>languoid</i> for each <i>PL-entity</i> . Further information about the genealogical status, related identifiers (glottocode, etc.) of the <i>PL-entity</i> and its status of encoding: review pending, definitely accepted, questionnaire version, etc.
Predecessor	A <i>PL-entity</i> which has been described as having asserted an influence on the described <i>PL-entity</i> . Any <i>PL-entity</i> can have multiple <i>predecessors</i> . If possible and applicable we also include predecessors which have not been encoded within the database.
Successor	A <i>PL-entity</i> which has been described as having been influenced by the described <i>PL-entity</i> . If possible and applicable we also include successors which have not been encoded within the database.

Term	Definition
Poetic Domains	We describe each <i>PL-entity</i>, with respect to three different aspects which we believe to be different enough to warrant a dedicated description strategy each: LS, the societal and historical embedding of the <i>PL-entity</i> as well as its prototypical narrative topics. LX, the levels of <i>poetic rules</i> which prescribe what a well-formed <i>composition</i> looks like, i.e. the <i>poetic system</i>. LO, the <i>ornamental system</i>. A collection poetic techniques that cannot be identified as mandatory, but rather represent <i>ornamental</i> preferences i.e. are optional but desired in their application. For details on how features are sorted in the database cf. the Questionnaire structure page.

Poetic Domains

As the phenomenon of Poetic language is of a social nature, but also rooted in language and dedicated to aesthetics, we decide to draw conceptional boundaries between, what we call, *poetic domains*. We describe each *PL-entity* with respect to three different *poetic domains*.

Within the *social domain*, we try to do justice to the social context of *poetic language*. The *rule domain* is concerned with the question of how language is patterned in order to be perceivable as poetic, i.e., *poetic system*. And finally, the *ornamental domain* explores the techniques and preferences behind poetic artifacts that is perceived as aesthetically pleasing.

Social Domain

Poetry appears within specific contexts, serving a variety of communicative and social functions. This *social domain* is assessed independently of the other domains; albeit to a limited degree as describing the complex social dynamics of human practices is beyond the capacity of descriptive linguistics and typology.

We mainly assess the modalities under which *poetic language* is performed and how performances of poetry relate to other performing arts within the culture.

Term	Definition
Era	The approximate time span within which compositions were written according to the poetic system of a given <i>PL-entity</i> . We thus define an <i>era</i> not by performance, but by active creation.
Chanting; Singing	As <i>chanting</i> or <i>singing</i> , we regard any rhythmical use of the voice in the performance of poems which goes beyond theatrical enunciation for dramatic or narrative purposes. I.e. patterns of intonation which are complex to a degree that is clearly beyond intonations as used in marking discourse pragmatics (cf. <i>music</i>).

Term	Definition
Music	<i>Music</i> and poetic form are separated in that the latter is based on linguistic building blocks, while the former is based on frequency modulations of instrumental or vocal sound. We consider <i>music</i> as what goes beyond supra-segmental intonation as it is used in spontaneous speech.
Instrument	Anything apart from human voice (cf. <i>Chanting; Singing</i>) which can be used to create sound. Also stomping, clapping, etc. count as being instrumental, the limbs being the instruments. We consider instrumental components as part of a multimodal performance of a poetic tradition.
Performer	We consider <i>performers</i> those who perform the verbal part of a composition. While <i>performers</i> may also act as musicians, the relationship is not reciprocal. Musicians, dancers and non-verbal choirs that do not act as <i>performers</i> of the verbal part of a <i>composition</i> are considered a distinct category.
Modality (Performance)	Poetic forms are often combined with other performing arts, such as dance, theater or music. We refer to such a combination as <i>multimodal</i> and to unmixed modalities as <i>unimodal</i> .
Performance occasion	A severe restriction regarding the circumstances under which the <i>performance</i> of <i>compositions</i> pertaining to the <i>PL-entity</i> is considered appropriate. Typically, <i>performance occasions</i> can be defined by their social, temporal and/or spatial contexts. E.g. spatial appropriateness may require that <i>performances</i> are held in temples, theaters, hidden gathering spaces and the like. Similarly, social appropriateness may require that <i>performances</i> are not regarded as recreational, but must be licensed by specific reason or event that they accompany.

Topics and contexts

In addition we collect information that pertains to the context of performance and the topics covered. A closed list of values is provided in the `values` Document.

Rule Domain

This domain is concerned with describing the patterns by which the *composition* of a *PL-entity* have to be structured in order to be differentiable from everyday speech as an instance of *poetic language* belonging to a specific *PL-entity*. For each *PL-entity*, we decompose these patterns into a collection of hierarchical and incrementally applied *rules* which, as a whole, constitute the *poetic system* of a *PL-entity*. By *hierarchical*, we mean that every *composition* can be described as a structure of layered *levels* LX. Each such *level* is formed by a regular *arrangement* of smaller parts, *constituents*. We term a well-formed instantiation of a *level* a *unit*. By incremental we mean that the *constituents* which are arranged in each *level* are themselves *units*, as produced by a lower *level*. That is, each *poetic system* draws at its lowest *level* from *linguistic properties* of the *languoid* within which it is composed. The *units* produced at this lowest *level*, L1 are subsequently *arranged* into larger *units* at a higher *level* L2. In this manner, a *composition* grows, one level after another, until it produces at the highest boundary of this hierarchy a recognizably complete *composition*; i.e. a poem that can be recognized as such on its own and is the complete product and aim of the poetic process of composing.

Depending on the requirements of a specific *PL-entity*, a minimally complete *composition* may range from a single rhyme to an epos spanning several volumes, s. *framework*.

Term	Definition
Composition	A structurally well-formed exemplar as a representative of a <i>poetolect</i> which can—in isolation—be recognized as a complete (cf. <i>completeness</i>) instance of <i>poetic language</i> belonging to a specific <i>PL-entity</i> . <i>Compositions</i> consist of—at least—two <i>levels</i> (s. <i>Hierarchical structure</i>). The upper limit of <i>levels</i> is set by the individual <i>PL-entities</i> and conceptually unbounded.
Completeness	Depending on the requirements of a specific poetic tradition, a <i>composition</i> may range in length from a few words to an epic tale spanning several volumes. We try to create comparability between such extremes by introducing the concept of <i>completeness</i> . A <i>composition</i> is minimally complete if it can emically be perceived as a well formed instantiation of <i>poetic language</i> within a given <i>PL-entity</i> . If a <i>poetic system</i> limits the potential size of <i>compositions</i> , a <i>composition</i> which has reached this boundary is considered maximally complete.
Level (poetic)	An abstract unit L of description designed to serve as a comparative concept (Haspelmath 2010), i.e. a universally applicable methodological tool with no claim for psychological reality, but for adequacy as a (qualitative) descriptive tool. A <i>level</i> LX is described in terms of the <i>rules</i> which determine how its <i>constituents</i> (LX-1 <i>units</i>) are <i>arranged</i> into valid LX <i>units</i> , which, in turn, may serve as <i>units</i> at a higher <i>level</i> LX+1
Constituents	Constituents are defined as the building blocks of a specific <i>level</i> LX and refer to the LX-1 <i>units</i> which are <i>arranged</i> at LX to form a specific LX <i>unit</i> .
Unit (poetic)	A <i>unit</i> is a specific and well-formed output of a <i>level</i> LX. The term LX <i>unit</i> refers abstractly to any well-formed <i>arrangement</i> of <i>constituents</i> at a <i>level</i> LX that can in turn be used as a <i>constituent</i> in the next higher <i>level</i> LX+1.
Validity	The concept of <i>validity</i> applies to all <i>units</i> produced at any <i>level</i> LX. Its definition is anchored in its usability as a <i>constituent</i> of the higher <i>level</i> LX+1: We consider an LX <i>unit</i> which is in sufficient compliance with the <i>arrangement</i> constraints of its own <i>level</i> , such that it may be used as a constituent of the higher level LX+1. The <i>units</i> which a <i>level</i> produces can vary greatly in <i>complexity</i> and <i>size</i> , as well as in terms of the <i>arrangement</i> constraints that apply to them.
Complexity, size	The number of different forms of relevant <i>linguistic properties</i> that play a role in the arrangement within a <i>unit</i> are a measure of its <i>complexity</i> . We register the two units with the highest and the lowest number of <i>forms</i> of a particular <i>linguistic property</i> as minimally and maximally complex, respectively. For both maximally and minimally complex units we distinguish their largest and smallest <i>size</i> in terms of the occurrences of <i>forms</i> required.

Term	Definition
Form	Poetolects typically distinguish between different forms of a <i>linguistic property</i> that are in a paradigmatic relationship, e.g., long and short forms of grammatical quantity, stressed and unstressed forms of prosodic prominence. These poetic paradigms are not necessarily equal to the paradigmatic might of the language in its mundane form. E.g., a <i>constraint</i> might impose restrictions on word properties by distinguishing between the forms monosyllabic and polysyllabic word, or it might refer to word boundaries, though neither of these categories are, from the viewpoint of descriptive linguistics, adequate descriptive characteristics to describe the linguistic system (grammar) of the mundane language.
Type (poetic)	If an LX exploits differences in the shapes of its <i>constituents</i> such that their <i>arrangement</i> within the LX is contingent on these differences (even though these differences are not relevant to their <i>validity</i> as <i>units</i> of their own <i>level</i>), we use the term <i>types</i> to distinguish the sets of <i>constituents</i> with unique distributional properties. Such <i>types</i> (i.e., paradigms of <i>constituents</i>) may be (co-)defined by more than one constraint. By (co-)defined we refer to the <i>rules</i> restricting what a well-formed <i>unit</i> at LX can look like.

Arrangement

While the *linguistic properties* refer to **what** is targeted by any *rule(s)* within a *level* LX, *arrangement* refers to the **how**.

For example, within a level, one *arrangement rule* may refer to *syllable properties* to constrain the amount of «syllables» in *level* LX to either 4 or 6. Simultaneously, another *arrangement rule* may refer to *prosodic prominence* to ensure that the syllables are arranged in a «iambic» pattern.

In many cases, an *arrangement rule* may refer to a *linguistic property* in a paradigmatic manner. E.g. our «iambic» pattern referred to the *linguistic property* of *prosodic prominence* as a paradigm which differentiates between stressed and unstressed syllables. We refer to the slots in such a paradigm as the *forms of a linguistic property* (c.f. *Type (poetic)*). Note that these poetic paradigms are not necessarily equal to the full paradigmatic might of the *languoid* in its mundane form. For example, a rule which makes reference to *word properties* might differentiate between «function words» and «content words». Whether these categories would be adequate descriptive characteristics within of a descriptive grammar of the given *languoid* is of no consequence. What counts is the emic perspective on the *linguistic property*.

Term	Definition
Count	In its simplest form an arrangement constrains the occurrence of a <i>linguistic property</i> such that minimally (or maximally) n constituents (co-)defined by the <i>linguistic property</i> must occur within a valid LX <i>unit</i> . The prototypical case is to count «morae», «syllables» or other linguistic units in a «foot».

Term	Definition
Covariation	An <i>arrangement</i> which does not constrain the <i>ordering</i> of <i>constituents</i> within a <i>unit</i> , but restricts their forms in an interdependent manner. That is, knowing the form of one <i>constituent</i> in the <i>unit</i> will increase the predictability of the form of one or more other <i>constituents</i> . The <i>units</i> which covary can be constrained to either share the same form of a property, or to disagree in their forms. I.e. they should be in «harmony» or «assonance». For example, <i>the lines of a verse must rhyme</i> . What distinguishes <i>covariation</i> from <i>counting</i> several forms at once is that at least one form must be known before one can predict the form of the covariates. <i>Covariation</i> can also call for several forms of the same property at once, e.g. <i>an LX must contain two nouns and one verb, irrespective of their order</i> .
Ordering	An <i>arrangement</i> which requires two or more <i>constituents</i> to be ordered such that the linear placement of its <i>constituents</i> is relevant to the well-formedness of the <i>unit</i> . From this definition follows that each <i>ordering arrangement</i> distinguishes between, at least, two different forms of the <i>linguistic property</i> it constrains. The prototypical case is a «foot» which contains a specific pattern of «stressed» and «unstressed» syllables. To illustrate, a «iambus» consist of an unstressed syllable, followed by a stressed one ~
Position	An arrangement which arranges <i>constituents</i> by requiring an absolute position: It may be important to register that position matters, e.g., a phonetic covariation constraint involving assonance may apply at specific positions within a poetic unit, differentiating unit-initial, unit-internal, or unit-final position.
Irrelevance	The default value which applies if the <i>linguistic property</i> is not subject to any constraints.

Ornamental Domain

We refer to any conventionalized means of enriching a *composition* with aesthetically pleasing attributes as belonging to the *ornamental domain*. The ornamental system of a *poetolect* is regarded as a collection of optional, but desired, poetic techniques which may appear strikingly often, but cannot be identified as mandatory. The *ornamental* system of a *PL-entity* is encoded in parallel with its *poetic system*. That is, ornamental techniques are also captured on a level-by-level basis. Equally, we anchor our variables within the space of *linguistic properties*. The difference being that we refer to the interaction between the *units* of a *level* not in the decompositional terms of *arrangement* by constraints which determine the *validity* (or *recognizability*) of *poetic language*. Instead we use the more flexible concept of *covariation* through which a *composer* can express their own signature above and beyond the formal requirements of a system without leaving the system. We are interested in how *ornamental* properties are emically correlated with specific aesthetic values.

Term	Definition
Ornamental system	A collection of poetic techniques that cannot be identified as mandatory, but rather represent <i>ornamental</i> preferences contributing to the perceived aesthetic value, i.e. they are optional but desired in their application. We speak of techniques and not <i>rules</i> since, whether a <i>composition</i> follows or violates these techniques is not relevant to the <i>recognizability</i> of a <i>composition</i> .
Ornamental (covariation)	<i>Units</i> containing a specific <i>linguistic property</i> , or a combination of several <i>properties</i> , are used within the <i>ornamental system</i> by the <i>composer</i> .
Avoidance (covariation)	An <i>ornamental avoidance</i> reflects observable, but not explicitly forbidden, use or appearance of a <i>linguistic property</i> within an <i>LX-unit</i> .
Irrelevant (covariation)	<i>Linguistic properties</i> which do not contribute, positively or negatively, to the perceived aesthetic value of an <i>LX-unit</i> are <i>irrelevant</i> .